How, then, is India faring on the world stage? The world is not what it was even a few years ago. That process of rebalancing was perhaps inevitable, even though its pace and quality were outcomes of political choices. The contribution that India has made to this rebalancing has not been small. At a symbolic level, it is recognized in the establishment of the G20 as a premier global grouping. This superseded a purely Western combination of G7 that lost its primacy after the 2008 global financial crisis. But the change of power distribution has many facets and expressions. It may be visible in economic activities, trade and investment figures, technological capabilities and market shares. But it is also evident in the debates of the day, such as on climate change, terrorism, black money and taxation as well as the pandemic.

India has emerged as a more influential voice in these conversations, as it has done on the consequences of the Ukraine conflict. And then there is the question of shouldering responsibilities, including beyond its shores. The record of addressing humanitarian and disaster situations since 2014 has clearly established India's reputation as a first responder in the Indian Ocean and its littorals, and with Türkiye, even beyond. The ambit of India's activities has also increased, towards the Indo-Pacific in the East and to the Gulf and Africa in the West. What India is saying, doing and shaping is a powerful reason why it matters.

This image has been sharpened by the independence of thought and action that India has displayed during the course of its ongoing rise. Maximizing freedom of choice has historically been an Indian approach. At times, it is done by keeping a distance; sometimes, perhaps better by voicing opinions. But, on occasion, it is also served by working with others on specific issues and designated theatres. After all, why should we not take advantage of convergences with other powers to advance our objectives?

Given that India has such a broad range of interests, it can only bridge contradictions through a multi-vector approach. In other words, the nature of the partners will depend on the nature of the problem. Others will try and restrict that freedom, seeking to impose a veto on our choices. We saw that in respect of Quad. India should never succumb to such pressures or hedge for the sake of hedging. The compass of national interest will guide us unerringly if we do not get distracted by ideological reservations or hidden agendas. The cultivation of such flexibility is all the more important because India will come to acquire a more leading position in the coming